This recipe is based on a classic African soup that is hot and spicy and full of flavor. The peanut butter lends a rich, satisfying earthiness.

african sweet potato soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 20–25 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

2 tbsp olive oil
1 onion, chopped
2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
2 tsp finely grated ginger
¼ tsp crushed hot red pepper flakes
1lb (450g) sweet potatoes, cut into small chunks
1 red bell pepper, seeded and chopped
1 x 8oz (230g) can tomatoes
1 tsp cumin seeds, dry-roasted and crushed (see p25)
1 tsp coriander seeds, dry-roasted and crushed
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable stock
2–3 tbsp smooth or crunchy peanut butter
few drops of Tabasco (optional)
chili oil, to serve

1 Heat the oil in a large pan, add the onion, and cook for 3 minutes. Stir in the garlic, ginger, and hot red pepper flakes and cook for 1 minute, then stir in the sweet potatoes, pepper, tomatoes, and crushed spices and cook for 2 minutes. Pour in the stock, bring to a boil, then simmer for 12–15 minutes or until the sweet potatoes are tender.

2 Remove from the heat and process in a blender until smooth. You may need to do this in batches. Pass the soup through a sieve to remove the pepper skin and then stir in the peanut butter, tasting to decide the desired amount. If you want to add more heat, add in some Tabasco. Reheat gently, then drizzle a little chili oil over each bowlful to serve.